

Burnout in the Berlaymont

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC GO

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GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, grateful Brussels has cooled down a tad — just in time for a spicy Playbook.

In today's Playbook:

- Why some staff say working at the European Commission can be a nightmare.
- The EU's migration chief wants the European Parliament to unblock anti-smuggling laws.
- Faces in the crowd: Ursula von der Leyen, Magnus Brunner, Timčo Mucunski, Nicolas Mavraganis, Alexander Dobrindt, Gianni Infantino and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Sarah discuss why working at the Commission is making some staffers so miserable.

DRIVING THE DAY

A TROUBLING TALLY: The European Commission received almost 1,000 staff reports relating to harassment in the last two years, the EU executive confirmed to Playbook.

Under strain: The figures come as a dozen staff across different departments and commissioners' cabinets told Playbook about toxicity and burnout in an institution that is increasingly taking on a geopolitical role under President Ursula von der Leyen. Read our full story here .

"The conditions are more and more difficult," said Nicolas Mavraganis, head of Union Syndicale Fédérale, a trade union representing European institutions.

The Commission hired an anti-harassment chief in 2024 to hear informal complaints about bad behavior. She leads a team of 40 counselors across the Commission and executive agencies. Since Sept. 1, 2024, the chief confidential counselor has received more than 960 requests from "colleagues feeling harassed, alleged harassers, witnesses, managers and HR correspondents," a Commission spokesperson said.

The volume of reports reflects greater awareness of those support services after mandatory anti-harassment training for thousands of staff, the spokesperson said.

Staff testimonies: But two officials, granted anonymity to speak freely, said they were not confident their complaints were taken seriously when they spoke up about being harassed. Another two said a senior official in a commissioner's cabinet has become notorious for "screaming" at staff, while a fifth official even recalled being physically struck by their superior at a bar down the street from the Commission's Berlaymont headquarters.

Brick in the wall: "It's the EU's executive, so people have this weird God complex," another official explained, arguing the sheer size of the Commission, which employs more than 30,000 people, means many staff feel powerless and voiceless. "You're just this tiny little molecule in this huge organism."

So why stay? For many, it's the perks. Officials at the AD5 level earn up to €7,000 a month and enjoy generous benefits, including a generally lighter tax burden and allowances. Around 170,000 people applied for just 1,500 graduate-entry AD5 positions earlier this year.

"It's golden handcuffs," one official told Playbook over coffee in the Berlaymont cafeteria, referring to the fact that many officials feel as if they are trapped because there is simply no better-paying gig out there.

A Commission spokesperson said the institution was "committed to being a modern, respectful and attractive place to work," citing an internal survey which found 74 percent of staff rated the Commission an attractive employer, up 6 percentage points from 2023.

The takeaway: Staff can value the mission, status and security while finding the daily reality draining. And while difficult bosses and stressful bureaucracy are hardly unique to the EU executive, officials told Playbook the combination of prestige, political pressure and the Commission's sheer scale contributes to a toxic culture.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked people working in the EU institutions to write in with their experiences of their workplace, whether good or bad. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

BIG AND BREAKING

HAVE YOU TRIED TURNING IT OFF? The EU's new biometric border-check system is causing such long delays for summer travelers that some airports are simply switching it off, writes Tommaso Lecca.

GAMBLING WARS: Brussels is bracing for an unusual fight between the EU's smallest country and a former British footballing legend, Gregorio Sorigi reports.

HEALTH PLANS ON ICE: Many EU-funded health projects are on hold amid a standoff between the European Commission and capitals over support for NGOs, Rory O'Neill and Claudia Chiappa write.

"A NEW LEVEL OF DANGER" ... Germany's Interior Minister Alexander Dobrindt said investigators are looking into whether an explosive-laden drone found at Leipzig/Halle Airport yesterday was part of a state-backed "professional hybrid threat scenario," per the Guardian .

INFANTINO CLINGS ON: FIFA apologized for its handling of its abandoned privatization plan after an emergency meeting of top executives last night — but Gianni Infantino remains president, the BBC

reports .

THE EU'S FORGOTTEN CANDIDATE

STUCK IN THE WAITING ROOM: North Macedonia is a star pupil for Brussels on paper — fully aligned with the EU's foreign policy and an eager candidate for membership since 2005. Yet two decades on, Skopje is still waiting for its accession talks to properly begin, and its patience is wearing thin.

Macedonians are mad: Foreign Minister Timčo Mucunski isn't hiding his exasperation. "Yes, we are at times very frustrated by the lack of political delivery," he told Playbook, adding that North Macedonia, which celebrated its Republic Day on Sunday, has become "a case study" in how bilateral disputes can derail the EU's enlargement process.

Quite a contrast: Montenegro is racing toward EU membership by 2028, Albania closed its first three negotiating chapters in July, and both Ukraine and Moldova are progressing in their talks. But North Macedonia has yet to close a single chapter in more than 20 years. "To say that we have been treated unfairly is an understatement," Mucunski said.

A Balkan affair: North Macedonia changed its flag in 1995, then its name in 2019 to settle historical disputes with Greece, only to find its EU membership blocked by Bulgaria, which is demanding that Bulgarians be recognized in the Macedonian constitution. Skopje doesn't want to do that, so its EU membership bid remains stalled.

No more concessions: The idea of amending the constitution has become politically toxic after "far too many" concessions, Mucunski said, adding Macedonians are tired of having "the goalpost moved" and don't trust Bulgaria won't simply demand something else. "This is an absolute misusing of one's position as an EU member state."

A Troubles comparison: Mucunski likened the situation to that of Ireland and the U.K., adding they probably could not have resolved their acrimonious differences without common membership in the EU. "Bulgaria ... right after us, they have the most to gain from our nation moving forward on the path towards full membership," he argued.

No Plan B: "I don't think that I will do anything useful in the interest of my country if I criticize EU decision-making," the top diplomat said. Still, he insisted North Macedonia has earned its place in the bloc, and wants the EU to come up with a "fair, predictable and credible path" forward. "Our country does not have the luxury of alternative B or alternative C," he said.

AFTER CEUTA

EXCLUSIVE — COMMISSIONER'S PLEA TO PARLIAMENT: Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner will use an extraordinary meeting of the European Parliament's justice and home affairs committee today to urge MEPs to revive the EU's stalled facilitation directive, arguing that the Ceuta crisis shows the need for tougher anti-smuggling laws.

"The tools are on the table. Now the Parliament and the Council must act without delay," Brunner told Playbook. "Europe must show that those who exploit vulnerable people for profit will be investigated, prosecuted and brought to justice."

Context: The Commission proposed the directive back in 2023 to strengthen penalties for smuggling networks, and member countries have already agreed their negotiating position, leaving it now up to Parliament to do the same.

But the Parliament's political groups are divided over whether the legislation sufficiently protects humanitarian assistance from criminalization, meaning the file has been unable to progress to interinstitutional negotiations, while civil society groups have also warned it risks criminalizing migrants themselves.

Brunner's message: "The loss of life in Ceuta is a reminder that migrant smugglers profit from human misery and put lives at risk," the Austrian commissioner told us, adding that the legislation is "robust."

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Partly sunny and a gentle breeze. High of 23C.

CONDOLENCES: Klaus Hänsch, the German Social Democrat who was president of the European Parliament from 1994 to 1997, died aged 87 . The institution will keep flags at half-mast today, an official told Playbook.

TOTAL ECLIPSE OF OUR HEARTS: If you want to watch next Wednesday's near-total solar eclipse at one of the organized viewing events, book soon — tickets are going fast. The eclipse begins at 7:18 p.m. on Aug. 12, reaching almost 90 percent coverage at 8:13 p.m.

Where to see it: In Brussels, the sun will be low in the western sky, so find a spot with a clear horizon. The Royal Observatory will open its radio astronomy station in Uccle, but the event is sold out. Further afield, you could head to Thor Park in Genk from 6:30 p.m., with organizers also hoping to see shooting stars . Or if you're in Antwerp, you can head up to the MAS roof to watch, no tickets needed . Over in Spiennes, near Mons, MUMONS and Olympus Mons are hosting a viewing at Silex's from 7 p.m.

The sun may be disappearing, but the risk of retinal damage won't: Eclipse glasses are apparently selling out around Brussels , though there were still a few pairs left when Playbook's own Zoya Sheftalovich got some for €3 at the Pharmacy Hecq near Arts-Loi last night. Look out for both a CE mark and the EN ISO 12312-2 safety standard on the glasses to make sure you're getting proper protection (sunglasses won't do the trick). Or you could do a Donald Trump and just look directly at the thing. (We're kidding. Please don't do this.)

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

London: Nigel Farage's Reform UK will announce plans today to jail chief executives and directors of companies that employ illegal migrants.

Paris: Bruno Retailleau appears to have cut a deal with a powerful mayor as he tries to consolidate the right behind his presidential bid.

Washington PM: Democratic progressives buoyed by Abdul El-Sayed's Senate primary win now have three months to show they can unite the party before the midterms.

AGENDA

— European Parliament's Civil Liberties, Justice and Home Affairs Committee (LIBE) holds an extraordinary meeting on the situation in Ceuta at 2 p.m. Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner, Ceuta Mayor-President Juan Jesús Vivas Lara and Spanish ministers are expected to participate. Follow live .

BIRTHDAYS

Former European Commissioner Didier Reynders; former MEPs Sara Skyttedal, Ramona Strugariu and Lars Adaktusson; journalist Jack Parrock.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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